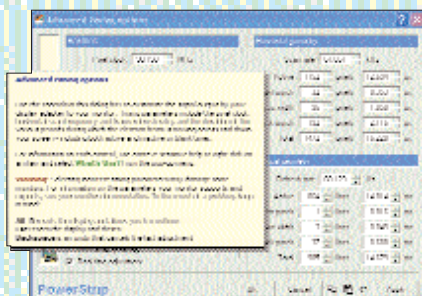


and memory speed settings of your video card. Once you've installed the software, right-click the icon in the system tray, highlight 'Performance Profiles' and click 'Configure'. Here, you can adjust memory and core speed individually simply by dragging the slider up or down.



Powerstrip—a tweak-packed utility

nVidia card owners can download a registry hack called Coolbits.reg (www.geforcefaq.com/files/coolbits.reg) that enables an option in the Windows Display panel to allow for core clock and memory clock overclocking adjustments without the need for third-party software. Who knew such a small patch could hold the keys for us to do so much?

Cool water

Overclocking is no mean task. You've got to be on your toes and keep heat levels in check when you do it. Two of the leading utilities—Rain (www.benchmark.com/rain.html) and Waterfall (www.benchmark.com/wfp.html)—help by cooling your CPU during periods of inactivity. It works for all x86-based processors from Intel, AMD and VIA.

The cooling process works by the software issuing commands that put the chip in a digital state of slumber when not in use. They only work for the Windows 9x/Me line because other flavours of Windows do the same thing automatically.

RAMming ahead

While the CPU sprints along with gigahertz swiftness, memory inches along at a fraction of that. Typically, overclocking system RAM is a tedious task but well worth the effort. Tuning memory to strike that heavenly balance between performance and stability can be made easy thanks to software such as SoftFSB (www.voodoofiles.com/250), a handy little application that lets users change FSB (front side

are more frequent. To overclock memory, you have to tune up the FSB. Simply select your mainboard manufacturer and model then slowly push the FSB higher, keeping an eye on system stability as you go on.

Athlons ahoy!

Without doubt, AMD's Athlons and Durons are among the most overclockable chips around.

Their immense potential has been given a shot in the arm thanks to a program (www.ocinside.de/download/l2_speed.zip) that lets you change the chip's L2 cache divider ratio—the limiting factor in most cases.

Often, Athlon overclocking attempts hit their limits not because the CPU core can't handle a higher frequency, but because the external L2 cache chips aren't up to it. In fact, AMD's own 750 MHz and 800 MHz Athlons use a lower speed L2 cache (2/5 divisor) than slower chips.

Once your chip is unlocked, that is, once the multiplier settings are open, push them as high as possible. As soon as you've reached a comfortable limit, use the L2 cache control utility to lower the divider ratio step-by-step until the chip will comfortably work at the next highest multiplier value.

Cyrix/IBM

Even low-end machines like some embellishment. For those of you still holding on to these dinosaurs, you can perk up chip performance by 10 per cent using 6x86Fast (www.hardwaresecrets.com/download.html), a utility that fully optimises CPUs for use with Windows 9x/ME.

Tweak the BIOS

Tired of a BIOS that won't let you tweak your machine for maximum performance? Don't let that get your hopes down.

TweakBIOS (www.miro.pair.com/tweakbios), perhaps the best BIOS tweaking utility out there, lets you tune just about every component of your PC without the need to reboot everytime you make changes.

It supports a vast majority of BIOS versions and chipsets, giving you more control over your BIOS than you ever had. All you need is a DOS prompt and you're on your way to a highly tweaked, high-performance power PC.

Cool CPU

It always helps to have reinforcements. When overclocking your CPU the hardware way, some software utilities can fortify your attempts by optimising the chip and keeping it cool at the same time.

That's what CPU-Charge (www.majorgeeks.com) is famous for; it even performs a variety of system optimisations to speed up memory and Windows itself. ■



It's the perfect tool in the dry season.

bus) speeds in Windows without having to restart the computer.

CPUFSB (www.voodoofiles.com/2679) is another package similar to SoftFSB, the only difference being that with the former updates